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launches, is usually two-three weeks prior to the processor launch. Hence, it came as a surprise when the launch was postponed till late August-early September. When the launch date neared again AMD announced another delay citing issues with the frequency not matching up to earlier projections. This time a new processor revision, B2 was to be launched. At the time of writing, AMD has already started working on revision B3. All companies do the same and AMD is no different, the announcement of the new revision so close to the launch had created a lot of flutter on the Internet. Finally, AMD launched the processors on October 12 though they are yet to launch the processor in India.

Then there was the news of AMD quitting BAPCo, a consortium that develops SYSMark. People were quick to claim a defect in AMD's product line. However, few noticed that along with AMD, NVIDIA and VIA also quit BAPCo over SYSMark 2012. With an NDA (Non Disclosure Agreement) in place, we'll never know the actual reason for the move but to claim a defect in AMD/NVIDIA/VIA's product range because of this development is baseless. AMD had recently cancel it's Komodo processor which was lined up for a 2012 release, it'll now be replaced by the Vishera platform which will incorporate a modified Piledriver (Bulldozer's successor) core.



Benchmarks, benchmarks everywhere...

Ever since an engineering sample of Bulldozer slipped onto eBay.com earlier this year we've been seeing quite a lot of benchmarks on the Internet. Most of those have been refuted as fake benchmarks. AMD mentioned that the Windows 7 scheduler doesn't distribute the jobs properly. For lightly threaded applications, this is pain as jobs are assigned to modules which can otherwise be parked (powered down). Therefore, if a job only requires a few threads, a better Operating System Scheduler will assign the job to less number of cores, thereby allowing the other cores to power down. Core parking was introduced in Phenom II and wasn't much of a success. A few benchmarks on Windows 8 developer preview have shown promise, an improvement of 10% was noted in Left 4 Dead 2, whereas the other applications tested only showed 2-4% improvement. Since the benchmarks were carried out on the developer preview, they are not indicative of the final product. So whether performance will increase by quite a bit or will it down the drain, only time will tell.

Another key thing to note is that Intel settled with FTC last year over an Anti-Trust lawsuit in which one of the complaints was that certain compilers would check the CPUID of the processor prior to executing the code. This allowed for the most optimum code to be executed

on Intel processors, but if the processor was anything other than an Intel, then the sub-optimal code would be executed. This has been widely reported and denied by Intel as well, yet it's not considered while benchmarking AMD products.

Of all benchmarks we have seen, Bulldozer seems to fit in snugly between Phenom II and Intel's Core i5 2500K. It has been priced aggressively as AMD always does but there isn't any significant improvement. Also, power consumption has increased dramatically which is to be expected from new architectures. Further refinements will reduce power consumption and produce much efficient processors, 4 processors have been launched this year, and 5 more will be launched next year, amongst them is the FX-8170 whose base frequency is 3.9GHz and scales upto 4.5GHz on turbo.

Final word

There has been a remarkable change in the architecture of the processor. AMD has been known to come up with innovations even though Intel's R&D budget exceeds AMD's entire revenue. The numerous changes in architecture will slowly be adapted into various compilers to make full use of it's unique design and we will probably see a huge improvement from Piledriver on Windows 8. We will be testing the processor and you can read about our take on its performance and the benchmarks in the next issue. 